

Jerusalem Letter

LIFE this year in Jerusalem promises to be interesting. We are making a good many experiments. One is the unpleasant one of trying to find out how little we can live on; another is the holding, for the first time, of final examinations and the granting of degrees in the Arts; another is the beginning of regular undergraduate courses, leading to an eventual degree, in the Biological Sciences. How the experiments will work out we do not know yet, but each one deserves commentary and explanation.

With regard to the first. We suffer, and seem likely to continue suffering, from a confusion between the heavenly and the earthly Jerusalem. The heavenly Jerusalem is paved with gold; or at least, so it is said. The earthly Jerusalem is paved (or, in places, *not* paved) with stones. We were never well off, and now the hard times which have fallen on all the world are falling with especial severity on us. The open hands which ten years ago built the new Palestine are now perforce looking after themselves, and when it comes to "cuts" education is always the first to suffer. I do not wish to give too gloomy an impression. The Friends of the Hebrew University in America, stimulated by the Chancellor's visit this spring, have guaranteed our budget for this year. But the necessary economies have been severe. We can buy hardly any books (would libraries with duplicates, or reviewers with surplus copies, please note?). We have no funds for publications, and even the two quarterlies which we are impelled to continue have to be pared to the bone. Salaries have been cut, all schemes for pensions and superannuation temporarily dropped; even the quality of our stationery is reduced. The "axe" has fallen alike on the just and the unjust. We are living in times of war.

It is worth considering a little further what this involves. A laboratory desires to undertake certain work of special character: it cannot—budget will not allow it. A scholar needs a photograph of a manuscript from Paris or Petrograd: we cannot get it for him—budget will not allow it. A second volume of a much-needed history of literature, or a valuable contribution to local (Palestinian!) archæology, or a transcript of a unique dialect which is fast

disappearing—all these and many others are crying for publication in vain: the budget will not allow it. We need an applied mathematician to complete our mathematical curriculum; we need a comparative anatomist to round off the new courses in biology; we need—but why specify? It is sufficient for us to remember that we could have had both an anatomist and a mathematician of the very highest order, only when it came to it we couldn't afford it. And the trouble is, of course, that such opportunities do not recur. The men we want, and could have had, go elsewhere. And so development is retarded; work is held up and workers become irritable; enthusiasm is damped and energy frittered away; and all because of budget, budget, budget.

It is more pleasant to turn to our first final examinations. We have had to fight our way through considerable difficulties before determining their shape. There exist varying conceptions, both of the organization of degree studies and of methods of examination, and for each there was among us at least one protagonist. Only the necessities of the situation brought decision. We adopted the system of requiring one major subject and two minor subjects for a degree, a system which would seem to be a half-way house between the "pass" and "honour" systems of the newer English universities. We are now watching the outcome in the first final examinations and are all a little anxious. Indeed, we are considering a scheme which by a more carefully controlled combining of subjects into "schools" will approximate closely to the "honour" system. In the meantime, we have had to settle many primary questions of technique which elsewhere are settled by tradition. For example: should examinations be in writing, or *viva voce*, or both? We have decided for the "both." Should "dissertations" be accepted in complete or final satisfaction of the requirements for a first degree? With us a dissertation is to be voluntary and may be offered in the place of one written paper. Apart from such points there are many minor questions of method and standard which it is hoped that increasing experience will overcome. The first degree, by the way, is to be that of M.A. Some of us thought the choice was a mistake and savoured of arrogance, although the degree is given after a minimum of four years' study, but the B.A. is in bad odour in the East and its record in parts of America is not heartening. So long as we keep the standard up, the title itself is of little consequence, and we are content in this matter to be Scotch. In connexion with degrees a very interesting suggestion from an old friend of ours in the country

is worth mentioning. He looks forward, as indeed we all do, to numbers of *graduate* students, particularly in Divinity, Archæology and Semitic languages, coming to Palestine for postgraduate work, and suggested that such work should be done under the ægis of the Jerusalem University for (as it were) a "combination" degree, a degree from another university being increased by the addition of "Jerusalem." Thus a B.A. or B.D. from Oxford or Edinburgh who could not stay long enough in the country to receive our research degree might, after a year's work under our supervision, become a B.A. (or B.D.) Oxon. (or Edin.) *et Hier.* If it could be worked, the idea seems an excellent one and deserves attention.

Examinations, however, and degrees, although not so gloomy as budget, are always tiresome subjects, and we may well leave them. The third point I mentioned, that of the introduction of teaching in the biological sciences, is far more interesting and important; indeed, it might be said to be the greatest advance we have yet made. Yet, in essence, it is an easy and natural development. We have always had a strong team of research workers among our scientific staff, and the emphasis in the scientific departments, whether by accident or design, has always been on subjects connected with life. All our men had to do was to get together and prepare a programme of courses for undergraduate study. The programme has been ready for years, but the stumbling-block has always been the subject of Physics. To teach in the sciences, even the biological sciences, without Physics was obviously impossible, but to open an institute of Physics in the real sense of the word was entirely beyond our means. We can only read with envy the accounts of the laboratories put up in more favoured places. After many disappointments we have decided to start in a very small way with one assistant lecturer (working under the supervision of a well-known physicist who is also the Chairman of our International Academic Advisory Council) and with a minimum equipment (I am ashamed to mention the small sum which was all we could squeeze out for it). But small though it is, our Physics laboratory will suffice to give students of Biology some idea of what physical processes are, and with that we shall have to be content to begin with. Chemistry, organic and inorganic, we can manage, and in the chemistry of living processes we are exceptionally strong. Our Mathematics Department has always been good, and we have fully-trained and experienced workers in Parasitology, Bacteriology, Botany and Zoology. The programme of studies differs from that of the Arts in that it is more highly organized, necessarily so as

there is so much basic information that a student of the Sciences must acquire. Personally, I have no doubt about the success of these new schools in the Sciences, and hope they will derive full profit from the experience we have gained in the Arts. I should add that this introduction of teaching in the Sciences is going to add materially to the choice of subjects available, even to students of the Arts. Exactly how far we can go at present is not certain, but it is clear that certain departments, that of Philosophy, for example, will work closely in connection with these new schools, and that certain subjects in the Sciences will count towards a degree in Arts.

A good deal of progress continues to be made in the tightening of the administration of the university. Internally we have tried to delimit the functions of the Institutes (the original units out of which the university was constructed), the Faculties and sub-Faculties (or whatever we call the teaching units), and the Professorial Council which, it is hoped, will one day grow into a fully-fledged university Senate. The differences of opinion held on these various functions were troublesome, however instructive, but in practice a middle way is being found without overmuch friction. Until the Professorial Council grows big enough to accept full responsibility the government of the university must remain in the hands of the international Academic Council, supported by the Board of Governors, which has helped us so much from the beginning. These bodies held a joint meeting at Zurich this year and came to some important decisions. At the same time many fundamental questions were left over. The whole problem of the conditions of appointment of the academic staff, for example, remains unsettled. An obvious reason for this was the financial depression. What is the use of arguing whether a university teacher is, or is not, to be appointed "for life" if the future of the university itself is uncertain? But for all that, very interesting points have been raised. Assuming, for example, that the system of family allowances is to be adopted, should the allowance be added to the maximum salary of the grade, or should it be included within it? On the one hand, the larger the family the more is the need of extra support; on the other, there seems no reason why one should mulct a bachelor who prefers, shall we say, books to bairns. Again, the problem of the nature of first appointments came up in all its rigour. Should a junior assistant go at the termination of his first appointment if he is not considered fit for promotion or if there is no room for him in a higher grade, or should all junior appointments be looked upon as probationary? Or again, there is the problem of leave. Should

leave be allowed to accumulate for a number of years, or should a fixed term be set for such accumulation? And, in addition to the ordinary leave, should a "sabbatical" year or term be granted, and if so, under what conditions and safeguards (our staff is so small that the absence of one teacher may involve the temporary closing of a department). You see that we are grappling with the same problems as all of you (incidentally, we scrutinize eagerly the material accumulated by the special committees of the Association of University Teachers). There is, of course, one important difference between our position and that of universities elsewhere. Universities elsewhere are parts of a whole system. We stand completely alone. We are not one of a number of similar institutions within which there is free movement of teachers and ideas. We are in a backwater, however important that backwater (the dividing line between East and West) may be. Whereas elsewhere it is becoming increasingly the exception for a man to remain in the same university or college all his days, with us it is likely to be the rule. But that, I suppose, is an additional reason for being more careful as to who is allowed to come!

One of the difficulties (and part of the fascination) of life in Palestine is that everything has to be discussed from the very beginning, and I have already given some examples of this. I may conclude these notes with one or two more. English educational circles have been ruffled now for many years by the question of the relationship which it is considered desirable should exist between school and university, the practical point at issue being that of the nature of the School Certificate examinations. In its barest form the problem is whether there is to be any connexion between the "school leaving" and the "university entrance" examinations, and, if so, whether the requirements of the university are to be the determining factor. To the continental tradition, of course, the question has no meaning. The "school leaving" certificate is the certificate entitling to entrance to the university, and as so many of our students come with continental school certificates, we had perforce to adopt the continental system of university entrance. It would have been difficult to refuse admission in Jerusalem to a student who would have been admitted without question to Heidelberg or Berlin. But at once we were faced with difficulties. The position of many Jews from Central and Eastern Europe is that they have either been precluded from studying in government schools at all; or have studied and, for political reasons, been granted no certificate; or have been granted certificates which have

afterwards been taken away from them (this last seems to have been the rule in Soviet Russia, where all personal papers, including even passports, were seized by government officials and deliberately destroyed). The logical thing to do was, of course, to arrange for entrance examinations of our own. But then the local schools took up the tale. They wanted us to supervise *their* examinations (again after the continental custom), so that *their* certificates should be recognized by European educational authorities. When we refused to do that, they wanted us to take over their examinations altogether, so that we should be ultimately responsible for the whole of local higher education. And now comes the point of principle I started with. Let us assume that we have the time and the energy and the men to undertake this responsibility. Is it really desirable that so close a tie should hold between university and secondary school? Is it not possibly truer that secondary education should be autonomous, an end in and for itself, and not merely a half-way house between the primary school and the university? Even if the university had the *power*, would it have the *right*, to determine the nature of secondary studies? Very strong opinion is against it, and we are still very hesitant.

My last example of our problems is that of the very being of the university itself. What is a university and who makes a university? Who made Oxford or Paris? And (to adapt the query of the small child) who made us? We are a "company of public utility" registered with the Government of Palestine. But most new universities are more than that. They depend on, and draw their legal existence from, a charter, and it is their charter which empowers them to grant degrees. But who is to give us a charter? The Government of Palestine? or the Colonial Office? or the Privy Council? or—strange but interesting idea—the League of Nations and its Committee of Intellectual Co-operation? It is a puzzling and interesting question, and its legal aspect may be left to the lawyers. But, so far at least as the giving of degrees is concerned, the university answer can only be this. A degree is worth as much as, and only so much as, the quality of mind and standard of work it is given for. A doctorate of all the Sciences and Arts together is worth nothing if given on mere payment of fee by a correspondence college; and no degree at all is worth everything if in the course of the work undertaken a man has learned what work means. And that, I hope, is the view which is to prevail with us here in Jerusalem.

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